4 Ethnographies of sailing

From the Red Sea to the Bay of Bengal in Antiquity

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Introduction

> If one happens to fall into the dreadful ocean, the abode of Nagas, marine monsters and demons, he has but to think of Avalokitesvara, and he shall never sink down in the king of waters.
>
> (Saddharmapuṇḍarīka Sūtra, 24, 6)

This was not merely an empty promise of protection from the dangers of shipwreck described in the texts, but the scene was also sculpted prominently in the rock-cut Buddhist caves at Kanheri, on the erstwhile island of Salsette off the west coast of India. Salsette was one of seven islands that were merged as a result of land reclamation projects undertaken by the British colonial government in the nineteenth century to form the present city of Mumbai. Kanheri, with 109 rock-cut caves was the largest Buddhist centre located in the fertile basin of the Ulhas River and dating from first to eleventh century CE. Most of the caves at Kanheri are located in small clusters between 60 and 90 metres above the surrounding plain. The caves are carved into three different hills with a stream flowing between them. Almost every cell contained a *podhi* or cistern where rainwater from the top of the hill was collected and at least ten of the inscriptions record donations of cisterns, tanks and water bodies.[1]

Merchants and traders were the major patrons of the monastic site. A six-line inscription in cave 11 dated 12 September 854 CE records the visit of a devout worshipper of the Buddha from Gauda or Bengal on the east coast and a permanent endowment made by him of one hundred drammas or silver coins for the construction of a meditation room and clothing for monks residing at the *mahāvihāra* at Krishnagiri, identified with Kanheri.[2] Three Pahlavi inscriptions in cave 90 indicate visits of Parsis to the Buddhist site in the eleventh century.[3] No doubt merchants and trading groups, both from within the region and outside it were prominent devotees of the Bodhisattva Avalokitesvara. Kanheri's island location and its promise made it an appealing place for travelling groups.

Other important islands on the west coast included Elephanta, Hog (Nhave) and Karanja islands, with the River Amba flowing past Karanja Island. Many of the islands, such as Elephanta, are known for their architectural treasures, rock cut caves, structural temples, and forts which survive to the present. Several of the

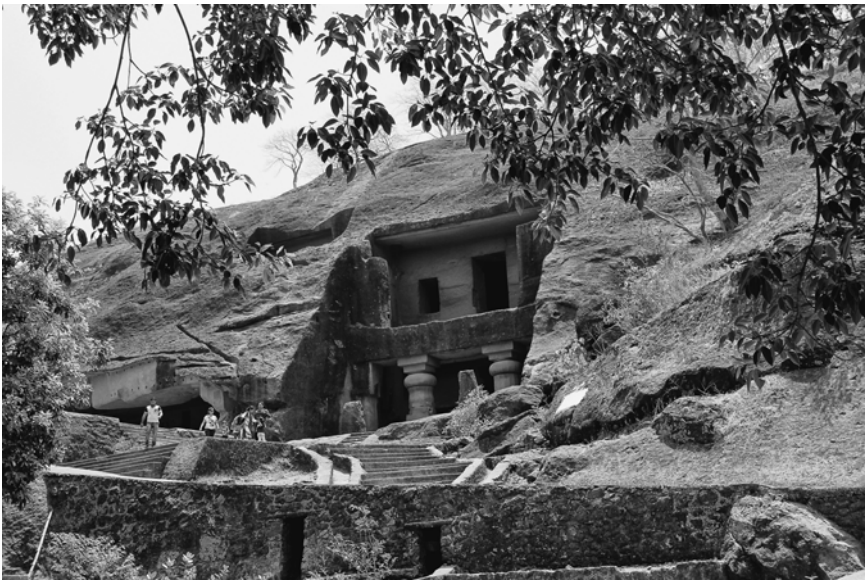

Figure 4.1 Overview of rock-cut caves at Kanheri on the west coast of India in the vicinity of the modern city of Mumbai (photo courtesy of Himanshu Prahba Ray)

rivers flowing past the islands were navigable and provided routes that linked the coast with the Deccan plateau across ghats/passes, such as Thalghat, Nanaghat and Bhorghat. Most of the passes and crossing points are also locations of Buddhist monastic centres dated to the early centuries of the Common Era. How are these early religious sites on islands and along the coasts to be understood?

This chapter shifts the spotlight from existing theories of economic history, which treat it as a linear development from a simple to complex economy with the need to identify a prime mover for the shift from agricultural society to urban cities. Instead, it underscores the concept of ritual economy, where the cultural and religious anchorage provided by early Buddhist monastic centres were vital to the development of both the political and economic structure. Economic developments need to be contextualised within a social structure.[4] This is an issue that has been dealt with earlier and will not be repeated.[5] In this chapter, the highlight is on coastal architecture and its interlinkage with travelling groups who moved both across the sea, as well as on routes into the interior. Monumental architecture along the coasts served dual functions; in addition, these were also used as major orientation points by watercraft while approaching land. Several examples may be mentioned, such as the Narsimha temple at Bhemunipatnam on the Andhra coast, and the Konarak temple in Orissa. Perhaps the most relevant example for this chapter is the Buddhist monastery at Nagapattinam, popularly known as the Chinese Pagoda, which was a major landmark on the Tamil coast from the seventh to the nineteenth centuries CE, when it was demolished to build a Jesuit college.[6]

This chapter begins with defining the geography of the west coast of India, described in some detail by the first-century *Periplus Maris Erythraei* (henceforth *Periplus*), before bringing the fishing and sailing communities and coastal centres into the discussion. This is followed by the larger context of the chapter, i.e. the maritime networks in the Indian Ocean, while the concluding section places this study within academic debates relating to 'trade' in early India.[7]

The West Coast: contextualising religious architecture

The Western Coastal Plain, the focus of this chapter, is best described as a narrow strip of land between the Western Ghats to the east and the Arabian Sea to the west. It ranges in width from 50 to 100 kilometres and extends from the present state of Gujarat in the north through Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka and Kerala. Numerous rivers cut across the region. Mostly originating in the Western Ghats, the rivers are fast-flowing, usually perennial, and empty into estuaries. Traditionally, the Indian coasts have been portrayed as inhospitable regions lacking natural harbours and afflicted with a shallow continental shelf and turbulent swells of waves. Did this deter trade and travel across the Ocean? This chapter answers this question by presenting an overview of vibrant seafaring activity in the period dating from the beginning of the Common Era to the seventh century based on both coastal and long-distance maritime networks.

It is no doubt true that the long coastal fringe offers only a few sites which provide deep water and shelter for modern ships as well as for eighteenth-century sailing ships. But in the period under discussion, ships drawing very little water were used in coastal navigation and were well adapted to these conditions. The practice generally followed was for sailing ships to anchor some distance from the coast and small boats were then used to transport cargo and passengers to the shore. Besides, voyages were made only in good weather and a rudimentary 'shelter' close to the river mouth sufficed as harbour. In the non-sailing period and for repairs, the watercraft was simply dragged ashore.[8]

The starting point for this discussion is Gujarat which is marked by a long coastline from the Gulf of Kachchh to the Gulf of Khambat and characterised by mud flats and saline wastes. As recently as 1970, this coastline contained 46 smaller ports and one large port at Kandla in Kachchh. These coastal settlements participated in trade with other centres further south along the Indian coastline and also across the Ocean, though each port specialised in a particular route. Mandvi, Porbandar and Veraval traded with East Africa, while Porbandar and Veraval traded with South Arabia, South East Asia and the Persian Gulf.[9] Thus route specialisation is an important aspect of seafaring activity that has far-reaching implications for a study of the past as well.

Another pertinent trend relates to shifts in coastal centres, for example, between the sites of Bharuch, Sopara, Kalyan, Chaul and Surat – all located on the Konkan coast in the present states of Gujarat and Maharashtra. It is important to stress that more than a thousand Buddhist caves were excavated in the hills of the Western Ghats and its offshoots at about fifty centres in the western Deccan. Broadly these

sites are located at passes along overland routes or overlooking creeks and coastal settlements. These shifts were linked both to silting of river mouths where the centres were located, as well as to changes in internal routes linking the coast to the capitals and cities of the interior. It was only with the transformation of the motley collection of seven islands with a variety of landing places into the port of Bombay in the nineteenth century that an identifiable and permanent port city was created on the west coast of India. Until this transformation, several landing places had been in existence in the vicinity of Bombay. It was between 1845 and 1859 that there was a need for the construction of the first docks for the steam-shipping companies as a result of the increasing naval and commercial importance of the site. A description of Bombay is illustrative of this practice:

> Originally, sailing ships for the most part remained anchored on the roadstead while goods and passengers were loaded and discharged by means of lighters which used an increasing number of landing places stretching from the Customs Bander in the south-east to Mahim to the north-west. None of these landing places was satisfactory, as they could only be used intermittently during some part of the day while at low tide goods and passengers had to be carried through the mud.[10]

The coastal belt of Karnataka extends to about 10 to 20 kilometres inland and is rich in mineral resources such as iron, copper, limestone, mica, gold, garnet, etc. Karnataka, with a coastline of more than 300 kilometres, has nine coastal centres, apart from a major port at Mangalore. Karwar, Belekeri, Tadri, Honnavar, Bhatkal, Hangarkatta, Malpe, Gangolli and Old Mangalore come under the category of minor or intermediate centres. Except for Karwar Port, which is all-weather, all the others are fair-weather harbours. The coastal belt of Kerala extending over 580 kilometres is relatively flat, teeming with paddy fields and coconut groves, and is crisscrossed by a network of interconnected canals and rivers. Thus a very different sailing regime from that functioning at present was in place. This was also reflected in the modest nature of coastal centres when compared to the present metropolises of Mumbai or Goa.

In the period of interest for this chapter, several dynasties are known to have ruled in parts of the west coast and were often in conflict with each other. Their orientation towards the ocean is however unquestionable. Valabhi, located on the Bhavnagar creek, at the head of the Gulf of Cambay, emerged not merely as an outlet for maritime trade, but also as the capital of the ruling dynasty of Maitrakas (493–776 CE) and the core area for religious consolidation. I begin with a brief overview of fishing and sailing communities that were vital partners in maritime networks and then discuss the archaeological data for coastal centres. Maritime trade has conventionally been viewed as trade in luxury items and controlled by the state. This is a model premised on the notion of empires which controlled trade and trading activity, as in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, a model that needs rethinking.[11]

The fishing and sailing communities

This chapter argues that fishing and sailing communities formed the foundation of maritime activity in the Indian Ocean and provided a continuum to seafaring throughout history, though no doubt their fortunes fluctuated over time. Fishing was the traditional occupation of coastal groups in several pockets of the Indian Ocean and this is an adaptation that dates to at least the fifth millennium BCE in several areas.[12] These communities adopted numerous occupations associated with the sea: fishing and harvesting other marine resources, salt making, sailing, trade, shipbuilding and piracy.

A common feature of the sewn boats of the Indian Ocean was the use of coir-rope for stitching. As coconut palm plantations were restricted to certain parts of the Indian Ocean littoral, coir-rope would have been one of the commodities in demand along the boat-building settlements of the coast. Thus, the building of the *dhow* or traditional watercraft involved trade and transportation of wood for planking and coconut coir for stitching from different regions of the Indian Ocean, thereby creating and sustaining networks of interaction. These maritime communities are to be distinguished from merchants and traders involved in oceanic trade.[13] Merchants and traders in some cases certainly owned ships and watercraft, but they neither manned nor sailed these. More often, however, goods and cargoes were entrusted to the skipper of the vessel who was then responsible for their sale and profit.

The first century CE *Periplus* perhaps provides the first detailed description of local boats in the Indian Ocean and several types extending from the East African coast to the west coast of India are referred to. The *Periplus* informs us that:

> Two runs beyond this island [Menuthias = Zanzibar?] comes the very last port of trade on the coast of Azania, called Rhapta [sewn], a name derived from the aforementioned sewn boats, where there are great quantities of ivory and tortoise shell.[14]

In the context of Gujarat, the *Periplus* refers to Syrastrene or Surashtra; Eirinon or the Rann of Kachchh beyond which lies Barake or the Gulf of Kachchh. This is a dangerous gulf to navigate for 'not only are the waves there very big and oppressive, but the sea is choppy and turbid, with eddies and violent whirlpools.'[15] After this the author mentions the Gulf of Barygaza, identified with the Gulf of Khambat.[16]

A range of communities participated in maritime activity at this time, such as the Nabataeans, Sabaeans, and Homerite Arabs, in addition to Indians. Does the *Periplus* indicate the ethnic identity of traders who traversed the sea lanes of the western Indian Ocean? Leuke Kome on the Red Sea coast was the harbour of the Nabataeans where craft, 'none large', loaded with freight from Arabia.[17] While discussing Muza or Mocha on the Yemen coast of the Red Sea, the text refers to Arabs – ship-owners or charterers, and sailors – who 'trade across the water and with Barygaza, using their own outfits'.[18] Another important harbour and storehouse at the entrance to the Red Sea was the island of Socotra, which was settled by Arabs

and Indians and even some Greeks, who sailed out of there to trade.[19] Merchants from Barygaza or Bharuch customarily traded with Oman and centres in the Persian Gulf and brought in supplies of copper and logs of teak and ebony. The Malabar Coast owed its prosperity to Greek shipping and also to traffic from Ariake or Gujarat.[20] On the east coast, the *Periplus* refers to Poduke, identified with Arikamedu near Pondicherry, where local boats mixed with those that sailed down from the region of the Ganga and from across the Bay of Bengal.

Thus it is evident that diverse local communities participated in seafaring activity, as reflected in references to local watercraft in the *Periplus*. A reading of the *Periplus* also establishes the absence of state control over maritime trade either in the region of the Red Sea or further afield, though it is true that the local polities attempted to extract revenues from the sale of trade commodities at market centres. In secondary writing on the subject, the emphasis has been on trade, often termed 'elite' enterprise conducted by ship-owning merchants, especially in the second millennium CE.[21] How is the relationship between the *nākhudā* or individual-in-charge of the ship and the merchant to be defined? Recent analytical study of the "India Letters"[22] has interrogated this connection. Margeriti in her study of Aden based on the published and unpublished records of the Cairo Geniza has concluded that the terminology used in them is ambiguous and it is not easy to distinguish ship owners from captains and other crewmen.[23] She also draws attention to differences in ownership of shipping craft and the role of State officials in the Mediterranean, as opposed to those in the Indian Ocean. In contrast to practice in the Mediterranean, in the Indian Ocean, while government officials did own ships, the Geniza papers suggest that merchants dominated this business.[24] This ambiguity in terminology and the need to distinguish modern practices from those in the Medieval period is further corroborated by a careful reading of the "India Letters", as evident in Friedman's statement:

> The ambiguity in terminology in our sources, especially in connection with the *nākhudā*, which certainly was used in more than one sense, and the difficulty in equating medieval terms with modern concepts present a major obstacle in any attempt to define the word with precision. Some *nākhudā*s were clearly ship owners; others evidently served as captains or may have filled other functions on the ship.[25]

The larger issue that this debate raises is the extent to which seafaring activity may be termed 'elite' and discontinuous. Archaeological data from coastal sites provides the much-needed corrective.

Coastal cities

Archaeological investigation in western India has provided information on several long-lasting coastal settlements. For example, the site of Mandvi on the Rukmavati River estuary at the entrance to the Gulf of Kachchh has been known as a town with links to both Oman and the East African coast since archaeological exploration was

conducted in the mid-nineteenth century. Dwarka located on the north coast of Saurashtra is another contemporary site with a long period of settlement from the first century BCE to almost the present. Other continuously settled sites along the Gujarat coast include Porbander and Somnatha and Valabhi at the head of the Gulf of Khambat. While sites such as Valabhi developed into political centres by the middle of the first millennium CE, others like Somnatha and Dwarka were sacred pilgrim centres of great sanctity. At Somnatha, archaeological evidence of historical settlement dates to the fourth century BCE, though religious structures, such as temples emerge only in the fifth–sixth centuries CE. Further south, Chaul, referred to as Campavati or Revatiksetra in the Epics, is mentioned in inscriptions and literary sources from the early centuries of the Common Era to the seventeenth century. In a copper plate record of 1094, three major coastal centres are identified and include in addition to Chaul, Thane and Sopara which were also in western India.[26]

Three copper plates dated to the reign of the Huna Toramana (fifth–sixth centuries CE) record gifts made to the temple of Jayaswami or Narayana belonging to the queen mother, donated by the trading community of Vadrapalli in Gujarat. The main commodities referred to in the plates are molasses, salt, cotton and grain, and a detailed list of revenues transferred is also enumerated. These revenues were calculated on the basis of vessel load, donkey load and cart load of the produce. Vadrapalli was probably located 8 kilometres to the west of Sanjeli on the west coast of India and signatories to the donation included traders from Ujjain, Kannauj, Mathura and perhaps Mandasor. A goldsmith constructed a lake near the temple.[27]

Of interest to this discussion is the charter of Visnusena dated to 592 CE, issued from Lohata in the Kathiawar region. This charter is addressed to a list of officials as is usual in records of the Maitraka dynasty (493–776 CE). The charter assures protection to the community of merchants (*vaniggrama*) established in the region and endorses their continued functioning.[28] It provides a detailed list of 72 trade regulations or customary laws to be followed. Some of the regulations are of great interest to this discussion. For example, it is specified that merchants staying away for a year were not required to pay an entrance fee on their return. Other clauses specify duties that were to be paid. A boat full of containers (*bhanda-bhrta-vahitrasya*) was charged 12 silver coins, but if the containers were for religious purposes, they were charged only 1¼ silver coin. In the case of a boat carrying paddy, it was half this amount. Other items, which were frequently transported by boat included dried ginger sticks, bamboo, wine, leather, buffaloes, camels and bulls. The variety of taxable objects mentioned in the inscription is an indication of the diverse nature of trade in the region. These included oil mills, sugarcane fields, wine, cumin seed, black mustard and coriander. The inscription also refers to a tax on dyers of cloth, weavers, shoemakers and retailers hawking goods on foot. Others such as blacksmiths, carpenters, barbers, potters, etc. could be recruited for forced labour under the supervision of officers.

A site that has gained prominence in recent years is that of Pattanam in Ernakulam district of Kerala. The Kerala Council for Historical Research has excavated at Pattanam since 2007. Along with locally produced pottery and beads, finds include

building structures, a wharf, a log boat, imported Mediterranean glass, Terra Sigillata pottery, and a range of amphorae dating to the first century BCE through the second century CE. Specimens of Sassanian-period (CE 224–651) torpedo jars from Mesopotamia, late Roman (fifth–seventh centuries) Aila/Aqaba amphorae, glazed Partho-Sassanian pottery, and sherds of probable South Arabian origin also are reported, thus locating Pattanam within the larger world of maritime networks in the western Indian Ocean.[29]

Arikamedu south of Pondicherry on the south-east coast of India is perhaps one of the few historical sites that have been subjected to several seasons of archaeological excavations. Initially excavated for six seasons between 1941 and 1950, the site was excavated again between 1989 and 1992 by a joint University of Pennsylvania and Madras University team. It is significant that in the Tamil coastal plains, Arikamedu was the largest Iron Age site, with an expanse of 8.4 hectares and an estimated population of at least 1,600. The earliest occupation at Arikamedu was described as a fishing village by Casal after his excavations, and fishing continues to be a major occupation in the region.[30] The settlement at Arikamedu grew along the river bank and the impetus for its growth was provided by trade rather than its association with the political elite, with fish being one of the traded items, along with pepper and paddy.

The archaeological record has confirmed that Arikamedu occupied a nodal position in the inland, coastal and trans-oceanic networks from the third–second centuries BCE onwards. We have elsewhere referred to the inscribed shards from Arikamedu, but also important are a range of imported ceramics that have been discovered at the site, further corroborating its long-distance linkages. Construction at the site was in kiln-fired brick with evidence for use of terracotta tiles, but generally was of poor quality and on unstable foundations. The period from the third to seventh century CE is indicated by architectural remnants such as a brick wall and innovations in ceramics, such as the red Rouletted Ware with parallels with sites in Andhra and further south along the Tamil coast.[31]

By the sixth century CE, Bengal is described as a region bordering the eastern sea (*prāksamudra*) in the Faridpur copper plates of Dharmaditya and by the eighth century CE, Dharmapala Deva announces his control of the oceans 'forming the encircling ditches of the earth'. The Khalimpur charters of the king were issued from Pataliputra 'where a variety of boats had formed a bridge on the Bhagirathi'. By the tenth century CE, the Bay of Bengal had acquired a territorial identity as indicated by the use of the term 'Vangasagara' in the Madanpur copper plate charter of Srichandra. From this varied imagery, it is evident that the waters formed a part of the cultural landscape of the communities in Bengal from at least the fourth–fifth centuries CE, if not earlier, and there was a vibrant transportation network along the rivers and the sea. I should also draw attention to the overlapping frontiers between Bengal and the kingdom of Arakan lying on its eastern edge, which saw cultural and religious interaction between Arakan and Bengal on the one hand, and Burma and mainland South East Asia on the other.

A coastal city that is vital to this discussion is that of Tissamaharama on the south coast of Sri Lanka. It was established on high ground on the left bank of the Kandara

(Kirindi Oya river) connecting it to the ancient harbour site and fishing village of Godawaya at the mouth of the river Walawe Ganga. The Buddhist shrine at Tissamaharama is especially revered as it is one of the sixteen places that the Buddha is said to have visited on the island, as stated in the fourth-century Sri Lankan Chronicle, the *Mahavamsa*. The Archaeological Department of Sri Lanka and the German Archaeological Institute have explored the ancient kingdom of Ruhuna in the south-east of the island since 1992. The oldest settlement on the citadel mound at Tissamaharama dates to the fifth century BCE, and has been identified as a village with small wooden structures. This expanded and grew and was also fortified. Several new structures were added including the tank Tissawewa, which was the main source of fresh water for the community of Tissamaharama. A third-century BCE pot shard from the site bore the graffito of a single-masted sailing ship. In addition, the excavations have yielded a large number of items imported from South Asia, thereby confirming the commercial nature of the site that prospered from the third century BCE to the fifth century CE. An important structure that was unearthed has been identified as that of a hospital. Though there is evidence for the abandonment of the citadel around 500 CE, settlement continued and monasteries flourished.[32]

A careful analysis of the pottery showed that in addition to the bulk of local pottery produced for household purposes, two groups of 'imported' wares were also represented: one found extensively in India, viz. Rouletted Ware and Red Polished Ware; while the second comprised of amphorae from the Red Sea and the Mediterranean. The Rouletted Ware is said to have a Ganga valley origin, and has been found all along the east coast of India from Tamluk in Bengal to Sri Lanka, as well as along the rivers that linked the coast to centre further inland. It is significant that Rouletted Ware pottery has been found at several sites in Thailand, Indonesia and Vietnam, and also westward to the Red Sea coast. There are several examples of Rouletted Ware mended with riveting at Tissamaharama indicating its significance at the site. In addition, there are parallels at sites such as Khor Rori (Sumhuram) in Oman.[33]

A further dimension was added to the dynamic maritime network as indicated by the distribution of pottery and its close connection to the Buddhist Sangha at the site by the discovery of the earliest shipwreck site in the subcontinent at Godawaya, dated from the second century BCE to the first century CE. The shipwreck has been excavated since 2012. An inscription from the monastic site refers to the collection of duties at the harbour and its transfer to the Sangha.[34] Fieldwork has revealed that, along with a variety of ceramics, stone querns and grinding stones, the ship was transporting a cargo of raw materials including glass ingots and iron ingots.[35] Other finds included grinding stones and four-legged querns, one of them with a short Brahmi inscription. It has been suggested that these querns may have been used for grinding medicines required at the hospital. Clearly, the results from archaeological work at Tissamaharama have provided insights into the participation of coastal centres in Sri Lanka in maritime networks as early as the fifth century BCE, as well as the development of urban centres in close proximity to monastic establishments.

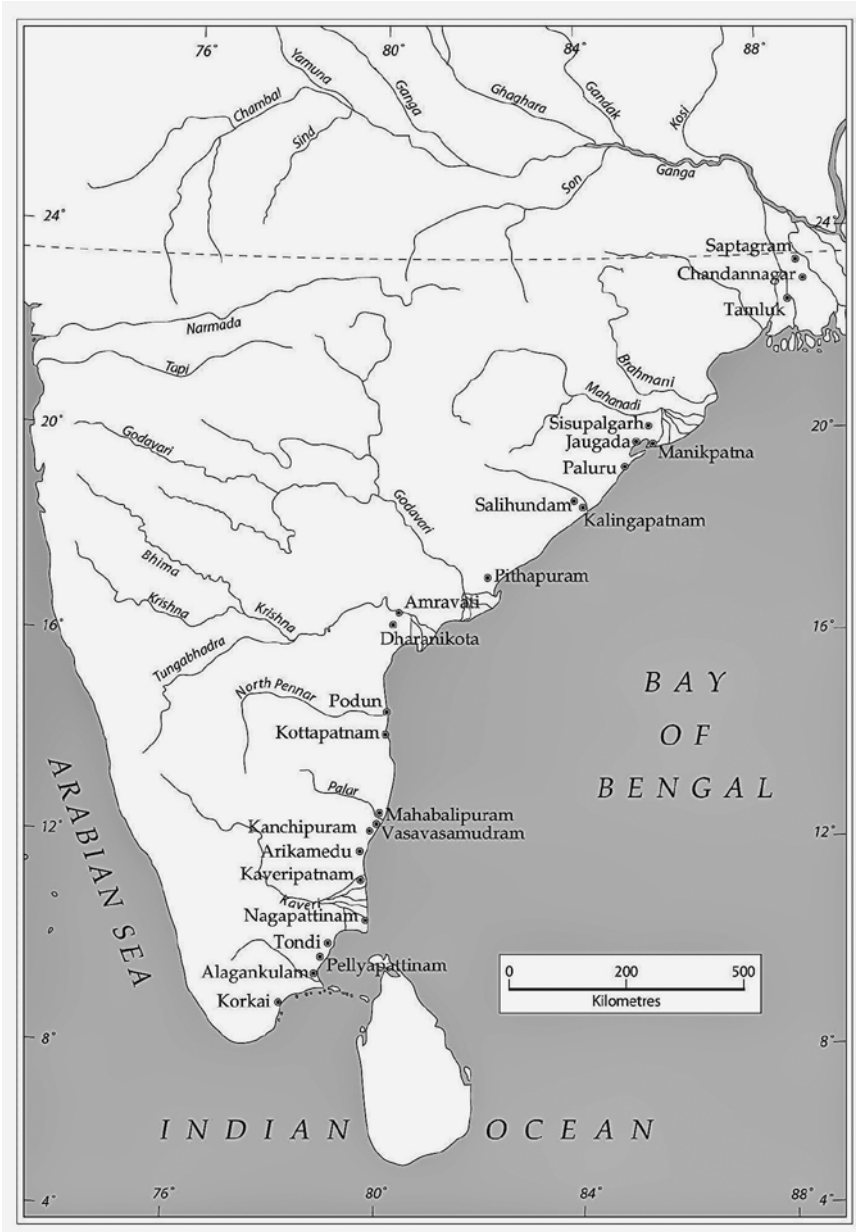

Figure 4.2 Map showing distribution of Rouletted Ware sites in India (courtesy of Himanshu Prahba Ray; drawn by Uma Bhattacharya)

This brief overview of the coastal centres raises the issue of who were the travellers that sustained these networks.

The travellers

While archaeology provides evidence for settlements, traded commodities and the watercraft used in maritime travel, literary sources add to that perspective by underscoring ethical and moral values that underwrote economic transactions in society. This is especially valid for tales used to propagate Christian, Buddhist and Jain values. The Nestorian Church became an important institution not only in Alexandria in Egypt, but more significantly in the Persian Gulf region by the fifth century CE. There is evidence for the reorganisation of the Nestorian Church in the region after the seventh century and growth and expansion at sites such as on the island of Failaka in Kuwait, Sir Bani Yas in the UAE and Kharg Island in Iran. The Church continued to maintain its presence until the end of the ninth century.

Kosmas Indicopleustes ('India-voyager') a Greek sailor from Alexandria who travelled to Ethiopia, India and Sri Lanka in the early sixth century provides a good example of interconnectedness of the Indian Ocean. In later life, he became a monk, probably of Nestorian tendencies. Kosmas tells us that he was a native of Egypt, probably of Alexandria, and never received a complete education (II, 1). He was a merchant (II, 54, 56) in early life, perhaps importing spices and made many voyages. He knew Palestine and the area around Mt Sinai (V, 8, 14, 51–52), had been to Socotra (III, 65), and had navigated in the Mediterranean, Red Sea and Persian Gulf (II, 29). He had rounded Cape Gardafui and sailed off Somalia (II, 30). Kosmas even mentions in book 2 another merchant, Menas, a friend of his, who also became a monk. His book, the *Christian Topography*, is dated to 550 CE. The surviving manuscripts of the text include an uncial manuscript of the ninth century, written in Constantinople (Rome: Vaticanus Graecus 699 (V); and No. 1186 of the Greek Manuscript of the Monastery of St Catherine at Sinai (S) dated to the eleventh century.[36]

The *Divyāvadāna* is a collection of 38 Buddhist biographical stories. The earliest *Avadānas* are verse narratives attributed to individual monks and nuns, though the *Divyāvadāna* may have been compiled as late as the eighth century. It portrays the adventures of wealthy merchants who later became Buddhist monks.[37] The second chapter in the *Divyāvadāna* narrates the story of *Pūrṇa* and celebrates both his business acumen as well as his wisdom when dealing with his recalcitrant brothers. This story reached wider audiences through paintings in the rock-cut caves at Ajanta near Aurangabad. It was also repeated in several Indian Buddhist traditions and translated into other languages, such as Chinese in 700 CE and into Tibetan in the ninth century.

A second text should also be mentioned at this stage, as it shifts the focus somewhat from the city and land to the sea. The *Daśakumāracaritam* or *What Ten Young Man Did* is described as a coming-of-age novel by Dandin (690–725 CE), which presents in autobiographical format stories and adventures of ten princes at the time of their reunion. It describes Valabhi as a prosperous centre. One of the

stories in the text is set in the city (*nagari*) of Valabhi in Saurashtra where the chief of the sea-traders (*nāvika-pati*) lived. He possessed immense wealth like the Hindu god and Lord of Wealth Kubera.

Dandin came from an illustrious family and his great-grandfather had migrated south from the court of the Vakatakas in Vidarbha in central India to take up the position of court poet of the Pallava rulers in seventh-century Tamilnadu. Travel and *digvijaya*, or conquests of the four directions, are strong leitmotifs of the stories and seem to reflect some of the author's own adventures as he wandered from kingdom to kingdom until he reached the Pallava court at Kanchipuram. Scholars have noticed some degree of inter-textuality and casual borrowings from the Jātakas and Gunādhya's *Brhatkathā*.[38] What is significant for this discussion is the vibrant description of life on land and sea, of trading caravans and merchants in Saurashtra, Dama-lipta and Kanchi, and several localities are used as the settings for the stories, such as Bhavnagar, Surat, Mathura and Ujjain. Merchants travelled over long distances, not only for trade, but also for choosing a bride, as in the case of Balabhadra who travelled with his wife and slave-woman (*panya-dāsī*) and settled in a hamlet, where Balabhadra used his business acumen to multiply his modest capital into a great fortune. When the servant-woman lodged a false complaint against him, he was brought to trial before the merchant *śrenī* or association.[39]

In the tale of Mitragupta, an unworthy prince is incapable of preventing his sister's lover from claiming the kingdom, though only after several adventures and fights. In one of them, he has him thrown in the sea:

> Adrift, my arms spun me this way and that before I could clasp to my chest a plank, destiny's gift. I floated until a whole day and night had slipped away. As the next dawn broke I spotted a vessel with yavanas [foreigners] on board. They pulled me up out of water and informed their captain (*nāvika-nāyaka*) Rameshu.[40]

It is suggested that Dandin drew on historic events in order to construct an elaborate analogy as a means of cautioning the young Pallava ruler against complacency. His objective was a political commentary on winning and saving the kingdom, but in the process, the author does refer to battles at sea and presents insights into a thriving business milieu.[41] To what extent are these narratives suggestive or reflective of a dynamic maritime network? This is an issue that I discuss in the next section.

The maritime network

The first point that needs to be addressed relates to the conceptualisation of maritime space. Two names are used for the Indian subcontinent in early sources: the fourth-century BCE minor rock edicts of Aśoka at Brahmagiri refer to Jambudvīpa or 'island of the rose-apple tree' and the same term occurs in the *Mahābhārata*;[42] and *Bhāratam varṣam*[43] or *Bhāradhavasa*, which occurs in the Hathigumpha inscription.

These terms were also accepted in Dravidian languages as loan words, e.g., *Manimekalai* 25, 12 (*navalantivu*) and *Cilappatikaram* 25, 173 (*navalantanpolil*), while the Persians referred to the north-west as Hindu corresponding to the Sanskrit Sindhu or river.[44]

By the second–first century BCE, royal inscriptions initiate the practice of defining the land under control of the king. Thus the record of Balasiri, mother of Gotamiputa Siri Sātakani, while recording the gift of a cave to the Buddhist Sangha, also contains a eulogy of her son Gautamīputa whose honorific titles indicate his sovereignty over a vast territory stretching to the shores of three oceans. This territory description is a practice that continues into later periods. Thus, while describing the history of the early Calukyas, the seventh-century inscription refers to Mangalīśa, whose army was powerful enough to invade all islands, crossed the ocean by bridges of boats and effected the plundering of the island of Revati.[45] Or the following verse in praise of the eleventh-century Western Calukyan ruler Tribhuvanamalla:

> May the king Tribhuvanamalla, by the ocean (*jalanidhi*) of whose spotless fame the world is encircled, render subject to his control the bride, which is the earth girt about as if by a zone, with the ocean, which is marked with sea-monsters, both male and female resembling elephants.[46]

Another region that presents a profusion of visual imagery involving the waters is Bengal. By the sixth century, it is described in the Faridpur copper plates of Dharmaditya as a region bordering the eastern sea (*prāksamudra*) and by the eighth century, Dharmapala Deva announces his control of the oceans 'forming the encircling ditches of the earth'. By the tenth century CE, the Bay of Bengal had acquired a territorial identity as indicated by the use of the term 'Vangasagara' in the Madanpur copper plate charter of Srichandra.[47] Clearly then the notion of sovereignty involved control over the waters of the oceans as well as land, and this is well represented in the royal inscriptions.

These linkages are nowhere more evident than in the case of the Indian Ocean and we focus here on the expansion of Buddhism across the Bay of Bengal. A cluster of fifth-century inscriptions of unequivocal Buddhist affiliation was found in Kedah on the west coast of the Malay Peninsula. This includes engravings of the Buddhist formula of dependent origination on stone – a feature that does not occur among contemporary records from the Indian subcontinent, though the formula is found on terracotta sealings. Three of these inscriptions are made of local stone and bear similar illustrations of Buddhist stupas. Texts very similar to these inscriptions have been found on the island of Borneo and on the coast of Brunei.[48] The most interesting of these inscriptions in Sanskrit is that of Buddhagupta, which refers to the setting-up of the stone by the mariner Buddhagupta, resident of Raktamrttika, identified with Rajbadidanga in Bengal, on the successful completion of his voyage.

There was a shift in maritime networks around the middle of the first millennium CE and pilgrims visiting sites associated with the life of the Buddha formed a major

Figure 4.3 Stelae with inscription of the mariner Buddhagupta found in Kedah, Malaysia, now in the Indian Museum, Kolkata (photo courtesy of Himanshu Prahba Ray)

category of travellers. No doubt Buddhist monks and nuns formed an important category of travellers. The image of early Buddhist monks and nuns as professional salvation seekers who distanced themselves from the world is being increasingly questioned, especially with regard to their role in innovation and social change.[49] The active role of the Buddhist clergy in the propagation of certain texts is also being increasingly emphasised. For example, the *Gaṇḍavyūha* enjoyed great prestige and popularity among the Buddhist communities of Indonesia, China and Japan. The Chinese obtained the text from Khotan and propagated it in at least three different versions all over the Far East. In the third and last translation, the *Gaṇḍavyūha* occurs as an individual text and not as a part of the *Avataṁsakasūtra*. The preservation and propagation of the *Gaṇḍavyūha* text in Indonesia may perhaps be discussed from a different perspective, i.e. its study and dissemination in the monastic establishments. More importantly, its prominent sculptural representation at Borobudur in central Java highlights the significance of religious travel in early Javanese society.[50]

Another network that needs to be taken into account is that with China. As recorded in the written history of the Han (*Qian Hanshu*) under the reign of Emperor Wudi (140–87 BCE), the emperor sent a mission to the kingdom of Huangzhi, which contemporary writers generally agree was located on the shores of the Indian Ocean, very likely in India.[51] More often quoted are records left by Chinese pilgrims who travelled to India and visited Buddhist sites. The pilgrim Faxian arrived overland in India in 399 CE and returned by sea to China in 413–414 CE from Sri Lanka heading towards the north-west tip of Sumatra. The ship was wrecked on the way and perhaps landed in the Andaman Islands. The next phase took Faxian to the north-west of Borneo where he arrived in 414 after ninety days at sea. The pilgrim remained in Borneo for five months and then left for China in mid-414 heading towards Canton.

A second Chinese pilgrim to visit India in the seventh century CE was Xuanzang, though he travelled by the overland route. In addition to the land routes into the subcontinent, there is ample evidence for the presence of sea routes across the Bay of Bengal. The most interesting information about circum-peninsular navigation of the Malay Peninsula is contained in Yijing's accounts of the voyage of the Chinese pilgrims who travelled to India and returned during the second half of the seventh century CE. Yijing provides an account of his journey from Canton in October–November with the north-east monsoon and his arrival in Palembang on Sumatra a month later. He stayed there for six months, and then went to Jambi near Palembang sometime around May. He stayed there for another two months and then re-embarked in order to profit from the south-west monsoon's winds to reach Kedah (Jiecha) on the west coast of the Malay Peninsula. He did not leave this region for India until the beginning of the following year when the north-east monsoon was well established. He reached the Nicobar Islands in ten days and fifteen days later arrived at Tamralipti in Bengal. This was clearly the most direct route to the holy places of historic Buddhism.[52]

Twelve years later, Yijing returned by the same route travelling on the winds of the north-east monsoon to reach Kedah, but this trip required two months, when

the outward journey had taken only 25 days. Sailing against the winds was a well-tried technique, but took much longer than sailing with the winds. One of the voyages recounted by Yijing lasted only the time of one monsoon – the pilgrim Wujing left China 'in the period of the east winds', i.e. in October–November and arrived in Srivijaya at the end of a month. After stopping at Jambi, he took another month reaching Jiecha and from there he left for Negapatam on the Tamil coast with the same winds before they began to wane towards the end of March. As late as the seventeenth century, the ships of the French diplomatic missions to Siam still had the same concern: they must not miss the 'season' as it took seven months on an average to sail from Brest and reach the Chao Phraya estuary.[53] How are these accounts to be contextualised within the framework of history writing in India?

Historiography

Traditionally, three broad trends have influenced historical studies on ancient India in the post-Independence period: one is the Marxist school, which supports the Indian Feudalism theory.[54] The paradigm opposing the theory of Indian Feudalism emphasises the centrality of the political structure in initiating change and suggests three discontinuous phases of urbanisation around which other economic activities coalesced. These phases have been defined as the Harappan (third–second millennium BCE), Early Historic (600 BCE to third–fourth centuries CE) and Early Medieval (sixth–seventh to twelfth–thirteenth centuries CE) periods.[55] While urban centres were characterised as centres of political power, surrounded by large agricultural hinterlands and located along trade routes in the Early Historic period, the character of these urban centres changed in the Early Medieval period into 'nodal points in local exchange networks', which were rooted in a regional context.[56] Three major historical processes have been postulated for the Early Medieval period within this framework: expansion of state society, assimilation and acculturation of tribal peoples, and integration of local religious cults and practices.

A third model for understanding the development of trade is evident in the writings by André Wink. He argues against the decline of Roman trade, since Greek-Byzantine traders again became active in the India trade from the fourth to sixth centuries CE.[57] In the fifth and sixth centuries CE, Persian commerce synchronised with the ascendancy of the Sasanian Empire, and with the coming of Islam there was an increase in trading networks in the Indian Ocean. Wink suggests that control of trade was a motivating factor in Arab conquest of Makran, Sindh, Kathiawar and Kachchh. The tenth century CE is marked by Arab and Persian settlements along the Indian Ocean littoral and the emergence of an integrated Muslim trading empire. Furthermore, according to Wink, Buddhism largely disappeared from India, in the Early Medieval period, though it continued to flourish in Gujarat until the ninth century CE. Finally, due to restrictions stipulated in the Law Books or the *Dharmaśāstras* on maritime travel, the Hindu population turned to 'agrarian pursuits and production, away from trade and maritime transport'.[58]

A few common points emerge from the prevailing secondary writings on early Indian history: first, that trade is closely linked to agricultural expansion and contraction; and second, that the impetus for oceanic trade is invariably placed with the foreigner or outsider – initially the Roman Empire and then Arab traders. New research over the last few decades, however, does not support this perspective.[59] As archaeology improves its methods and techniques of analysis, it becomes apparent that fishing and sailing communities formed the backbone of maritime travel. The presence of these communities along the Indian west coast dates to at least 5000 BCE. These communities adopted numerous occupations associated with the sea, such as fishing and harvesting other marine resources, salt making, sailing, trade, shipbuilding and piracy.[60] The commodities involved in trade ranged from salt and cowries at one end of the scale to costly textiles, silverware and dancing girls, at the other.

The conception of a merchant class separate from production is increasingly doubtful – as often merchants were landowners, mine owners and organisers of manufacturing, as well as owners of cargo vessels. Maritime activity involved diverse groups, from the owners of watercraft to those who commanded these, and still others who sailed them. Hence there can be no simple caste attributions of the communities involved in trading activity. Moreover, the normative rules laid down in the Law Books or *Dharmaśāstras* need to be balanced against narrative literature in Sanskrit, which provides glowing accounts of maritime travel, by merchants, craftspeople, musicians and others.

There is little evidence of state -sponsored trade, though rulers were constantly devising means for taxing and controlling the lucrative business. Trade involved a complex hierarchy of transactions, such as gifts to those in authority, barter and monetary exchanges at the local and regional level. Only commodities required by powerful groups were controlled. It is significant that while archaeological data and distribution networks of ceramics indicate local, regional and oceanic interaction, starting from the third–second millennium BCE onwards, inscriptions are largely silent about trading activities until well into the fifth and sixth centuries CE, when trade becomes profitable enough to be taxed. From this period onwards, inscriptions reflect an increasing complexity in the commodities traded and in the nature of transactions conducted.[61] The post-tenth-century period marks a further change, with shops and markets in the vicinity of temples contributing materials to the performance of rituals and festivities. For example, the thirteenth-century record, inscribed on a long slab of polished black stone from one of the temples at Somnath on the Gujarat coast, refers to the purchase of shops by the benefactor and their donation to the temple.[62]

Conclusion

In the final analysis, the Indian Ocean maritime network in the early centuries of the Common Era involved a variety of groups including artisans, craftspeople and transporters, rather than ruptures and discontinuities, occasionally revived by external stimulus. The history of these communities is evident from the donations

that they made to religious establishments. Thus trade and trading activity cannot be studied in isolation from the diverse religious landscape that developed in the subcontinent. This chapter has attempted to highlight the location and archaeology of religious structures, thereby placing the shrine in its wider social base. It also needs to be appreciated that the religious architecture was by no means unique; instead it was part of a diverse sacred geography. For a comprehensive appraisal of

Figure 4.4 Map showing distribution of Buddhist sites in India, especially along the coasts (courtesy of Himanshu Prahba Ray; drawn by Uma Bhattacharya)

crafts and communities in the subcontinent, the intertwined strands of religious architecture, economic activity, and political intervention need to be examined and understood. An overview of this activity, as presented here, amply demonstrates the participation of maritime communities in a variety of networks – local, regional, and trans-oceanic.

Notes

1 Ray (2018).
2 Gokhale (1991): 70–71.
3 Gokhale (1991): 142.
4 Ghosh (1973).
5 Ray (1986).
6 Ray (2015).
7 Ray (2011).
8 Deloche (1983): 439.
9 Orton (2001).
10 Broeze (1992): 254.
11 Ray (2007).
12 Ray (2003): chapter II.
13 Ray and Salles (1996).
14 Casson (1989); *Periplus* 16.
15 *Periplus* 40.
16 *Periplus* 41.
17 *Periplus* 19.
18 *Periplus* 21.
19 *Periplus* 30.
20 *Periplus* 54.
21 Compare for example the statement: 'Possessing considerable wealth, these ship-owning merchants can be considered as elites in the ports of coastal western India and were also known for their patronage to religious and cultural activities.' Chakravarti (2000): 38. The *nakhudas* in this paper are considered ship-owning merchants.
22 Goitein and Friedman (2008).
23 Margariti (2007): 223–224.
24 Margariti (2007): 21–22.
25 Goitein and Friedman (2008): 138.
26 Mishra and Ray (2017).
27 Ray (2007): 39–61.
28 Sircar (1953–54): no. 30, 163–181.
29 Shajan et al. (2004): 351–359; Cherian (2011).
30 Casal (1956).
31 Ray (2003).
32 Schenk and Weisshaar (2016): 459–479.
33 Schenk (2006).
34 Falk (2001).
35 Carlson and Trethewey (2013).
36 McCrindle (1897).
37 Tatelman (2005).
38 Onians (2005).
39 Kosambi (1959): 292.
40 Onians (2005): 412–413.
41 DiCaroli (1995): 671–678.

42 *Mahābhārata* VI 12,1; VI 8,19.
43 *Mahābhārata* VI 10,8; *Vāyu Purāṇa* 45,75; *Viṣṇu Purāṇa* II 3,1.
44 Scharfe (1989): 14.
45 Fleet (1879): 13.
46 Fleet (1879): 11.
47 Sircar (1949): 337–339.
48 Christie (1995): 256.
49 Schopen (1988–89): 153–168.
50 Ray (2001): 110–127.
51 Wheatley (1973, first published 1961): 8–13.
52 Jacq-Hergoualc'h (2002): 53–54.
53 Jacq-Hergoualc'h (2002): 55.
54 This credits the introduction of iron around 1000 BCE with expansion of agriculture and production of a "surplus" in the middle Ganga valley. This surplus was then invested in trading ventures, which emerged around the middle of the first millennium BCE. Trade with the Roman Empire led to the development of urban centres in the early centuries of the Common Era, but with the decline of the Roman Empire and consequently its trade with India, these towns and cities were abandoned. A period of agrarian expansion and self-sufficient village economy followed, lasting until 1000 CE when foreign trade revived under the Arabs. Sharma (1965).
55 Chattopadhyaya (1994): 167. The period between the sixth–seventh and twelfth–thirteenth centuries CE showed developments vastly different from the society of the earlier period: 'State formation was a crucial agent of change in this respect, in the sense that it brought a measure of cohesion among local elements of culture by providing them a focus' (p.35).
56 Chattopadhyaya (1994): 181.
57 Wink (1990): 45–64.
58 Wink (1990): 72.
59 Ray (2011): 27–54.
60 McPherson (2007): 34–49.
61 Jain (1990): 56.
62 Bühler (1892).

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